



Mother and baby homes (including pre-1948 Workhouses) and Magdalene laundries oral history project

Interview with LP

Anonymous (LP)

4th January 2018

England

Interviewed by Olivia Dee

Transcribed by Pete Hodson

Livi Dee travelled to England to interview LP in her family home. LP entered a Good Shepherd mother and baby home during the 1980s when she became pregnant. LP explains that her convent school education left her naïve about sex and how to avoid pregnancy. She was 20 years old and a university student. She explains that the baby's father was very immature and unwilling to take any responsibility. LP knew that her parent's response would be highly negative. She visited a priest to ask for advice and soon afterwards was liaising with a social worker. Once a plan for a mother and baby home and an adoption was in place, LP felt able to talk to her parents. They were not very emotionally involved in the life of their children and made it clear to LP that she needed to sort out this situation by herself. Reflecting on the role of the social worker, LP believes that there was a conflict of interest between her role as an advisor to LP and working for a Catholic adoption society. Speaking about her time in the home, LP described scrubbing floors and cleaning toilets right up until she gave birth. However, she did not view this as problematic, reasoning that she was a fit young woman. She did, though, reflect on the fact that much of this cleaning was ritualistic, unnecessary and symbolised her position within a hierarchy within the home. LP has good memories of the two nuns that worked in the Good Shepherd mother and baby home and believes the system was the problem rather than these two individuals. She shares a very uncomfortable memory of being sent to confessions after she arrived and an elderly priest

asking her inappropriate, intimate and upsetting questions about her sex life. LP compared the embarrassment she was forced to go through in admitting her ‘sins’ to the way in which the father of her baby got away scot-free: as did most other men in the same situation. Among the other girls and women in the home with LP was a twelve-year-old who had been raped by her father and LP speculated that this abuser may have sat prominently at his local church while his daughter was hidden away from view.

After giving birth to her son, LP was told by hospital staff that it was ‘best’ if she did not see him. However, she did get to see him before the social worker took her back to the home. LP describes having to return to the home after she had given birth because she was struggling emotionally. She had given her baby up for adoption only because she felt that was no other alternative open to her. LP has suffered psychologically following this and discusses its impact on her life. Her relationship with her parents was also damaged and LP resented the way in which they treated her as a result of the simple matter of her becoming pregnant. Shame was imposed upon LP by her parents, but this also fractured her relationships with numerous family members. LP blames her parents’ Catholicism for this and discusses a letter she wrote to the Catholic Church about her experiences and the reply she received: one that she felt was insincere with no real understanding of her feelings.

LP hopes that one day her adopted son will try to reunite with her. She has gone back to the record holders to ensure that they have her current address. Having had a successful career, marriage and raised two further children, LP still feels that there is a piece of the jigsaw missing in terms of her adopted son and she constantly wonders about him and the life he is living.

To protect LP's anonymity and that of others referenced in her interview, redactions are made. These are indicated by **.

OD: Okay, just for the purposes of the tape – my name is Olivia Dee, and I'm in England with an anonymous interviewee who's going to tell us about her experience of *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home* in 198*?

LP: Yes.

OD: And it is the 4th of January 2018 [*sic. 2019?*]. So that's just pick up, don't have to worry...So we've already had a bit of a discussion about what your experience was, and we've talked a bit about how you felt? So, I just want to ask a few questions around that to try and get a sense of your timeline?

LP: Mhmm.

OD: So how old were you in 198*?

LP: Twenty.

OD: Twenty?

LP: Mhmm.

OD: And so you found yourself pregnant at the age of twenty?

LP: Yes.

OD: Okay. And how did your family react to that? And were you, obviously, living at home when you were twenty?

LP: I was at university.

OD: Oh okay, yeah, yeah.

LP: I was at university in *university redacted*. And I was living in *district redacted* I think, in a shared house with six other girls. Yeah.

OD: I've done that.

LP: We're all meeting up again.

OD: Are you?

LP: In March this year.

OD: Oh wow, that's amazing.

LP: Yeah, yeah. It is.

OD: I don't think we could manage that – there were too many fights. So you discovered...did you have a boyfriend or partner that was...

LP: I was going out with a boy. I hadn't been going out with him very long and he wasn't terribly faithful. He was nineteen, so he was a little bit younger than me. But he lived at home with his parents.

OD: And was he at university?

LP: No, no. He was working for his family business.

OD: So, did he remain in the picture when you found out you were pregnant?

LP: No. We had finished by this stage.

OD: Okay.

LP: As I say, I don't think he was terribly faithful. And he was like a summertime fling sort of thing. And I was at university, and I don't know whether I was very naïve or...I don't think I realised I was pregnant, but I knew there was something up.

OD: Right.

LP: And I went to doctors on campus and I think I was over twenty weeks pregnant when I...

OD: Wow. So that's...

LP: I was very naïve.

OD: So that's almost five, that's five months? Wow. So, what kind of symptoms were you showing at that time that made you think something was wrong? Was it just basic things like no period, or...?

LP: No period and my abdomen was thickening.

OD: Yeah.

LP: I wouldn't say that I was...I wasn't sure whether it was pregnancy or it was a tumour? Because I was very naïve. I mean, nobody had ever explained the facts of life to me, apart from what you'd done at school, you know? I was a very, very naïve girl.

OD: Yeah.

LP: And as I say, I just knew that there was something forming in my stomach. I mean I hadn't put on any weight necessarily.

OD: There was like a heavy...

LP: It just felt like a little something there.

OD: Yeah.

LP: And, of course, when I went, that's what it was. I hadn't, I hadn't any symptoms of sickness or tiredness or any of those things that you get when you know that you're pregnant.

OD: And were you – obviously because you're away from home...

LP: Yeah, yeah.

OD: ...was your instinct to call your family, or?

LP: No.

OD: No.

LP: No. Because I knew – or I thought I knew – what their reaction would be.

OD: Yeah.

LP: I knew that I was in big trouble, and that I was going to have to sort this out.

OD: So, when you say ‘sort out’ do you mean...what?

LP: Deal with it...

[Husband enters room and short conversation follows. Husband exits room]

LP: Oh yeah, so what was I saying? Oh yes. So, I knew I was in a bit of a situation to put it mildly. I’d also, one of my friends from school, was at the uni as well. She wasn’t doing...She’d become pregnant a little bit before that and she had gone to England and had an abortion. So, when I told her I was aware that, you know, what she had done.

OD: And was that quite well known at that time that you could do that?

LP: No.

OD: No. Okay.

LP: Not at all. Not at all.

OD: So, did you ask her for advice?

LP: I think I spoke with her, but I think I knew that that wouldn't be an option for me. I mean I felt that I'd got myself into this and that I was, I was going to have to get myself out of it. I contacted the father and told him that I was pregnant – and quite pregnant. And he came up, I remember he came up very late one night. We were all in bed and the door went and it was him. I invited him in and he came in and I told him what was going on, and he was so juvenile, you know? And irresponsible and 'well I'm not interested' – you know? He was not going to have anything to do with me or the baby.

OD: So, the strength was going to come from you, all the...

LP: Yeah. He didn't want to know really. And he couldn't get away quick enough. He'd got his friend sitting in the car waiting for him. Yeah. Very immature. Yeah. I don't think he's ever married. He, he is known to my brother and my brother doesn't speak very highly of him.

OD: Yeah.

LP: Or he didn't at the time. But so anyway, he wasn't interested and he came from a very, very well-to-do family so really, financially, there wouldn't have been a problem because he was working and... But he just didn't want anything to do with me or the child. And again, it was my responsibility, I felt. So that's when I walked up to the priest's house in *district where LP's student house was located* – just knocked on the door – and he was actually the uncle of a girl who was in my year group, and just told him what had happened.

OD: What did it take for you to go to a priest with this? Was that terrifying, or did that feel comforting to go there?

LP: No, it didn't feel comforting, but I think I knew that, that there were places for these, you know, unmarried mothers to go. I think I thought he would practically be able to help me, really.

OD: So, it was more the kind of 'I just need someone that can give me practical help'.

LP: Yeah.

OD: Yeah.

LP: Because I was convinced that my parents would have nothing to do with me and would throw me out and create a scene...I knew for certain that they wouldn't want the child. But I also thought that I would be ostracised as well, as...I think growing up and going to an all-girls Catholic school, I had heard of other girls that had, you know, had similar things happen to them and their parents and done this and that, you know? Or that they'd gone off, gone off somewhere and hadn't come back, you know? And everyone...

OD: Everyone knew?

LP: ...so it was all hush-hush, secret. So, I went to him and I don't know what happened then. I think, perhaps, a social worker came to see me. She was from *name of town redacted* – where I'm from – and she came to see me. And I had uni to finish, I had that term to finish so...and I'd practical exams to take

that year. So, I had to go and tell my tutors, and my personal tutor was very kind – as was the head of year, she was very kind. And they sort of, I think they made sort of slight allowances for me. I mean they were very confidential about it, they didn't tell everyone, but they made allowances for me for the practicals that I had to do.

OD: Good.

LP: And my head of – *name of academic redacted* was my head of thing – and she lived on the *location redacted*, and I remember going to see her when I was in *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home redacted* and she was a very nice lady. But, so, then I think term finished and – oh yes. So, then I thought well, I'm not going to ring them, I'll write to them and just say: 'Look, I know I've got myself into this spot of trouble here, but don't worry about it. I'll sort it. I've got plans'.

OD: Ah, so you felt like you could talk to them once you had presented your solution?

LP: No – I thought...I didn't think I would be talking to them. I thought I would tell them what has happened, and that they would automatically not want anything to do with me, and I would have to sort it out because they weren't going to...They weren't going to offer. I mean my parents were very...my father wasn't there a lot, because he had a job working *occupation redacted* and after he finished his shift he would go out to his mother's place. She had a small farm and he would help on the farm, and then he'd come in at night time. So, if he worked an early shift he would come home at teatime, but he'd be gone from like half four in the morning? So, I mean he wasn't there a lot. My mother was very...non hands-on. She wasn't interested in, you know, how you

were doing at school or what career you were going to follow or...She was just interested if you helped with the housework, you know? Their idea of having children was to have people to do things for you when you got a bit older, you know? So, everything I did, I went to my interview at uni by myself, the first day at uni I went there by myself.

OD: Wow.

LP: I packed a bag and I went – that was how it was done. So I was, I was...They weren't the kind of parents who were involved in the decisions that you made. I mean when we took our son to uni we packed him up and bought him everything.

OD: Oh yeah. My parents did that for me, yeah.

LP: And mine were just...And the standing joke was always my mother sent me off with a packet of orange Club biscuits – because that's all I went with. So, you know.

OD: And did they help you financially when you were at university, or did you...

LP: No.

OD: Okay. So, did you work?

LP: No, no. We had grants then.

OD: Oh of course.

LP: We had it easy. But I didn't get a full grant. But she'd slip me the odd fiver here and there, but they always said: 'We can't help you, we can't help you'.

OD: Did they support you going?

LP: They were very pleased that we all had gone to grammar schools and we'd all, you know... There was a bit of an arrogance about them all that we were all educated, you know, because they hadn't been. They weren't stupid people, but they just hadn't been educated.

OD: Well sometimes it's not about stupid...it's about opportunity isn't it?

LP: Yeah, yeah. Yeah they hadn't got – didn't have – the opportunity to go. So, I wrote to them and I was sitting in college and my brother came to the door, and I thought 'Here we go'. So, they'd obviously got the letter and my mother and my brother had come up to the university. And my mother said: 'How far on are you?' And I told her and she said: 'Are you all right?' So that was...yeah.

OD: Was that a surprise to you?

LP: And then we came home and nobody said anything. My father came in that night and he didn't say a word. And I just told them what I had been planning and what was going to happen and they just went: 'All right'. So, they told me they were too old to take on a child, but I don't remember there being much discussion about anything 'cos we weren't that kind of family. My brother was at home, my youngest brother was doing his 'A' Levels and my middle brother was still at home. My sister was in *GB city redacted* and she was coming

home to get married in *month redacted*. And, of course, I had landed with this situation. I had an older brother too and he had just had a child, a little girl. But there was never any talk that the baby was going to be kept or what we would do, or...And I mean part of it was me as well, because, because I was so self-sufficient. I think I thought I knew what I was doing.

OD: Yeah. Probably it seemed like an easy solution, or at least a practical solution to something?

LP: It was definitely the easiest solution for everyone.

OD: Yeah.

LP: It was the one that caused least disruption to everyone. It was the one that kept everything secret and quiet and caused them the least embarrassment, I suppose.

OD: So, when you say that no one talked about it, was it that they ignored you completely or was it just as if nothing had happened?

LP: It was as if nothing had happened.

OD: So, they still carried on talking to you about your course or your day or things like that, but there was no mention...?

LP: Well they wouldn't...Well no, they didn't talk to me about anything. They weren't those kind of parents. They weren't really very interested in...Daddy would say things, well, no. I was frightened of my father, though. I was

frightened of him because he was quite a harsh guy. He was very abusive when we were children.

OD: Like violent?

LP: Yeah. Yeah. And emotionally abusive as well. So... They just weren't cut out to have children – but they had five of them.

OD: Wow.

LP: So, they kept going. They were very odd people. Very unloving, very 'we need to be seen to be doing the right thing' – to be at church, to be here there and everywhere.

OD: And I'm assuming very, very Catholic?

LP: Very Catholic, yeah. Very Catholic.

OD: And are you – or were you – still in contact with them?

LP: I was in contact with them until about ten years ago. And I was in contact with all my family and I would've gone home and seen them, and they didn't necessarily come over this way very often but, you know, we would have made a trip home – when the kids were small – two or three times a year. We would do the duty visits and, you know, and 'I'll take you out for dinner' and that sort of thing. But always it was 'I'm trying to make it up to you'. I'm trying to show you that I am really quite a nice person, and this awful thing that I have done, you know, was just... My brother was sleeping with his girlfriend before they got married. My sister was sleeping with her boyfriend before, you know? The

actual what I have done wasn't worse than what they have done, it's just that I wasn't cute enough, I wasn't clever enough, I wasn't as well informed or as well prepared, really.

OD: Did you have any idea of what you could do to protect yourself against pregnancy? Or was that something that no one talked about?

LP: Not really, no.

OD: Because by 198*, obviously, you'd think that it would have kind of permeated?

LP: Not where I was brought up. I went to a convent school, you know? My parents – my mother – never spoke to me about anything like that. No. Not really. So...I've got a little plant thing [talking about dogs?], one's got something the other one wants. No.

OD: Sorry, I'm just...the card's full on this one [referring to the recording machine] I'm just going to re-set it. So, I suppose then another part of this that I'm really interested in is how you come to the home?

LP: Oh right, yeah. Well, I think it was the social worker, because I think she came to see me in my digs? Because she worked for...this is the other thing that was so wrong, was that the people that were offering you advice actually worked for the adoption agency – the Church-funded, led, whatever – adoption agency. So, it was to their advantage for you to say, you know, I think this baby ought to go to a good, loving Catholic home – but not mine.

OD: So, was that *name of adoption agency redacted*?

LP: Yeah, probably.

OD: So, you knew that the social workers were involved with the Church?

LP: Oh yeah, yeah, yeah. She was, she was in it.

OD: So, was there a lot of pressure on you from the social workers or anyone else to give the baby up? Or was it just always assumed that would be the case?

LP: I think it was always assumed. I'm trying to be fair, here, because...It's easy in hindsight to think certain things, but...I'm trying to be fair because I think she – I mean her mission was to get babies for Catholic children – Catholic parents. Excuse me, they've got something they shouldn't have. *[To dogs]* What have you got, you Arabs?. Come on. *[Resumes answer]*. To get Catholic children for Catholic couples that couldn't have children of their own, you know? That's definitely her mission in life and what I would say was that I, I probably gave her the impression that that's what I wanted, because it was – as we said before – it was the easiest thing to do. It was the thing that cause the least distraction. It meant that I could go back to university and pretend it never happened. And it was a solution of sorts, but... *[Dogs yapping]*. Little rotter.

OD: There we are. *[That will]* calm them down a bit. Just for the tape, there's two quite small puppies here – that's who we're talking to.

LP: But the main...I don't remember ever thinking that there was a viable option. I don't ever remember thinking, you know, I could keep this child. I remember thinking I would like to keep this child, and in fact after, after I'd had him and came out of hospital I arranged to see him again.

OD: The baby?

LP: And I actually had to go back to stay in *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home redacted* for a bit because I was so distressed by it all.

OD: So, you come to...who brings you to *the home*?

LP: The social worker did.

OD: The social worker. And what are your first impressions?

LP: ...The place was very austere. It was a very clinical place with dormitories and old-fashioned bathrooms and things. Very clean and clinical and...the two nuns that were there in my time – Sister C was one of them – and I thought she was a wonderful lady. She had sort of very prominent teeth and a cracking – a huge – bust and a cracking smile. I mean compared to what I'd come from, which was a very cold...

OD: So, she was a bit more cheerful maybe?

LP: She was much more loving, both in her practicality and in her...She was quite a joyful person, you know? I've seen a lot of nuns and you usually get the old crabby ones – most of them are old and crabby, but me, I felt that she was a very joyful, good, person.

OD: Yeah.

LP: Doing a job that at the time, you know, needed to be done. She was a midwife as well. She had been a midwife, so she was very good from a reassurance point of view.

OD: So, she was able to say ‘This is normal, this isn’t normal’?

LP: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah.

OD: And who was the other sister?

LP: Sister M. And she was a nice lady too, but she was much quieter – probably a bit more stern. But I can’t fault, I can’t call...Personally, I couldn’t fault either of them. They never did anything hurtful or anything to me. It was the system that was wrong. They were servants of the system, so whether they share some responsibility because of that? But I think at the time, [over] thirty years ago, I think they thought they were doing the best thing, you know?

OD: Yeah.

LP: I mean hindsight is a wonderful thing. And I mean I felt that I was safe now because I was somewhere where I would be safely with my pregnancy and it could be resolved. They organised for us to go to the local hospital and, I mean, we went as a group so when we arrived people knew we were the girls from *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home redacted*.

OD: And how were you treated?

LP: I don’t think...I don’t remember...I mean I had no idea what was going to happen. I had no idea how I was going to have this child.

OD: So, no idea physically how you...

LP: No. Or what the process of having it would be like.

OD: Did you have any idea – or any guesses, or?

LP: No.

OD: No?

LP: And when I went into labour...I mean we went to the hospital together – it was probably a logistics thing as well, we'll send them all in in a taxi, you know? I mean we were lumped together. I don't think they treated us any differently than...

OD: Was this *name of hospital redacted*?

LP: It was, no, *names another maternity unit* *[To dog]* Oh she's eating it – we have to take it off you then if you're eating it. I don't know where you got it from, but you shouldn't have it. Let go. Let go. Right. Have the rope instead – look, here. No, don't eat that. *[Resumes answer]* There was a Catholic doctor who was, he was charged with looking after...

OD: Was it Doctor *name deleted*?

LP: Maybe? Something like that. Quite an Irish sounding name.

OD: Yeah.

LP: He was looking...I mean, I don't remember him being particularly nice, but...I don't remember anything terrible about him either. The priest who was the priest there at the time, the first time I went there they insisted that I would go to confession.

OD: To *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home redacted*?

LP: [Yes]. To confess all my sins about what an awful girl I was, and...And I remember at the time him – which I thought was really odd – this man of God who's supposed to be celibate, asking me what I had, where I'd had sex and whether I'd masturbated or anything like that, which I thought was really...really odd. Yeah. To divulge all my, all my awful, awfulness so that he could forgive me.

OD: So that was the priest?

LP: That was the priest. He was an old boy. And I remember coming in and thinking 'God that was embarrassing'.

OD: What was the purpose?

LP: Yeah. He had to do that to save my soul. I had to spit out all the wrongdoing that I'd done in order for him to...He might have been a funny old boy, you know? There's a few of them about, I'm afraid, in the Catholic Church. So, he may have...but anyway, I found it very odd and I felt very...upset by it.

OD: Yeah, I'm not surprised.

LP: He had painted me as being this harlot, you know? That...

OD: I just wonder what the purpose was of...obviously you're there, your pregnant, it's obvious what happened – but I don't understand the...

LP: Well, it's to get me to confess before God what awful, you know, having sex with this guy was truly terrible that, you know, I have to confess and make contrition for it. And we were all, you know...A lot of the girls in *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home redacted* – certainly when I was there – were like me. They were naïve, stupid, came from very staunchly Catholic families where nothing was ever – sexuality was never talked about, relationships were never talked about and you get this clever guy that thinks he's God's gift impregnating you and then clearing off.

OD: Yeah.

LP: And that was one of the things that I read in the paper about how these men bore no responsibility for these children?

OD: Oh yeah. And they're not going to homes, they're not...

LP: And they continued – their life continued to flourish within the Catholic Church and within society and how they got off scot-free, and the burden that we've all carried for these many years.

OD: They probably didn't have to go and explain everything they'd ever done to a priest?

LP: Well, I don't think even his, his family even knew. I don't think he had even told his family that they had another member of their family somewhere.
[To dog] Stop it. Stop it. No. No. Look at my shoes – they're bad enough.
Right, that's enough. No. I'll smack you on the nose. I will. No – go away...

LP: ...Yeah. The nuns were fine. The regime was very...

OD: Yeah. What was your routine? Can you remember?

LP: You get up, you got breakfast, you tidied up. They gave you chores to do.

OD: What kind of chores?

LP: Scrubbing floors, cleaning loos.

OD: But did that stop when you'd got quite heavily pregnant?

LP: No.

OD: So, what kinds of...so even sort of nine months pregnant you'd still be cleaning?

LP: Oh absolutely, yeah.

OD: Was that tough?

LP: Well, I was twenty years old.

OD: But pregnant?

LP: Yeah but...

OD: Nine months?

LP: Pregnancy's not an illness, it's just a process. I mean... See the impression that I was given – or that I had – was that I ought to be very grateful for where I was? Even nowadays I still show my gratitude by doing things. So, me cleaning their toilets wasn't a big thing, really, because look what they were doing for me? Looking back on it, it was very oppressive. Looking back on it, there was lots of girls that... their self-esteem was so low *[To dog]* Oh. Stop it. Stop it. I'll put you out. *[Resumes answer]* You know, were we treated badly by having to do those things? Doesn't that, isn't that what – through history – isn't that what people do to other people that they don't think are good enough? They give them...

OD: Menial jobs?

LP: Yeah, menial jobs and they, you know, they... Cleaning somebody else's toilet is sort of, you know, it's indicative of what your position in life is – or what your position in their society is. It's...

OD: Was the cleaning kind of necessary? Was it dirty enough to need...

LP: No, it wasn't dirty.

OD: So, it was more like a ritual?

LP: It was spotless. It was, yes, it was more like an occupation. Give these girls something to do – idle minds, you know? Idle minds have idle thoughts. I mean there was some girls in there who came from *location redacted* and they were worldly-wise and, I mean, they could have taken them [the nuns] on any day. But the majority of girls that were there when I was there were foolish little girls that had got caught and they were from different parts of Northern... There was a twelve year-old girl there who'd been raped by her father – who was probably still sitting in the front row of the church that weekend.

OD: And when you met someone like that, were they treated differently because it was...

LP: No.

OD: So, there was no kind of different treatment for girls who had clearly been...

LP: No.

OD: Because you'd think even, you know, at that age that you can't really consent...

LP: She was the most beautiful girl you've ever seen. It was so distressing. Yeah. Yeah. I mean she didn't know what was going on with her at all. And then, I mean, when I said to you about I didn't know what was going to happen when I had the baby? I remember getting signs that I was going to go into labour and Sister C said: 'I'm going to examine you and then I'm going to send you in'. So, she rang an ambulance and here am I, twenty years old, being taken into a maternity hospital by two ambulance men that are complete strangers.

OD: So, she didn't go with you?

LP: No. I remember we had to go in sort of through a long tunnel, and it was at night-time, and being so deathly scared because I didn't know what was waiting for me.

OD: And were you – were your labour pains a surprise? Did you know it was going to be painful?

LP: Well, I think, actually, they sent me home the next day and...because it was like the beginnings of it, they sent me home, and then I went back in again that night. I mean my mother knew that things were starting because I'd rung her to say that Sister C thinks it's going to be any time now. I mean she [was] still sat in *name of home town redacted*. Didn't...But the following day I did go in and...I mean I think they gave me a lot of medication?

OD: So, you think you had pain relief?

LP: Because I think I was a bit out of it. And they were very kind to me.

OD: In the hospital?

LP: In the hospital. But I mean I had no idea how painful it was going to be, you know, in the run up to it? I had no idea about that. But as I say, I think I probably had lots of pethidine. And then he was born and he was just taken away – that was it. And I said: 'Could I see him?' And they said 'No'.

OD: Had you made any requests beforehand not to see him?

LP: No. And they said: ‘No. It’s best if you don’t’.

OD: So, they framed it like they were...

LP: Yeah. ‘It’s best if you don’t’. Or ‘This one’s for adoption’ you know? They were words to that effect. So, then I was taken to – afterwards – taken to the ward and I had terrible pains from milk, and there was one really nice midwife who said: ‘I’ll give you some Epsom salts and that’ll help you’.

OD: To stop the milk...

LP: Yeah. He was in the nursery and I did bring him up to the room to have him by my bed. My parents came up – my mother and brother came up to visit the night after he was born. The...I said to mummy: ‘Do you want to see him?’ And she said: ‘No’. So, then I think I was in hospital for two or three days, because you were in those days.

OD: Yeah.

LP: And then the social worker must have come in, and then she came in on the day I was going home. So, I just marched out past the nursery and off we went, and she took me back to *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home redacted*. And I stayed there for a bit and then I think she took me home. I went home within a week, I suppose. And then I was back into work placement, and then when that finished I was back at uni. I maybe saw her...I had to sign paperwork, I remember, and I had to...I did ask to go and see *son’s name redacted*, and I did see him. I think it was in *name of baby home redacted* that we went to? The foster mother brought him up from wherever he was and I

did see him. And then I signed final paperwork... *[To dog]* Oh god, stop that. *[Resumes answer]* And then...I went home after I signed the...it was in where...you know where *location redacted* is? Whatever. But it was in a front room of that building, and the social worker was there.

OD: Yeah.

LP: I think that was the only person that was there. And I just signed this paperwork and went on my merry way. I came home that night and my sister and her fiancé had just appeared, you know, come back home for the wedding. It must have been *month redacted*. And there was much excitement about the wedding and I said to my mum, just quietly, “I’ve signed the papers today for *son’s name redacted* adoption.”. And her words to me were: “Oh don’t make a fuss of it now, *sister’s name redacted* [has] come home to get married.” So...That’s that. And as I say, I had a relationship with them until maybe ten years ago and I was very ill, mentally ill – as I have been on-and-off throughout the years – and I just couldn’t do it anymore. I couldn’t do the pretending.

OD: Did you try and have a conversation with them?

LP: Yeah.

OD: Or did it just stop and say...

LP: Yeah, no I wrote to them and I said: ‘Look, I just can’t do this anymore’. I can’t live my life trying to make it up to you.

OD: That’s really brave.

LP: Well, it was a matter...I had got so low that – and it was all to do with them and *son's name redacted* and...Well, my upbringing, Catholicism and all that nonsense and them being the people that they were. It was just a pretence. It was just a game that we were all playing. They were strong enough to play the game and to continue to play the game, but it was just eating away at me because I just couldn't stand it any longer. And I thought, you know, I know what I did wasn't that bad, you know what I mean? You're the people that are wrong here. So, I wrote to them and I said: 'Look, I don't like the way you treat me and I don't like the way you treat my children' – because whatever negative feelings they had towards me it transcended the generations? So, my sister's children were wonderful, my children were little brats. They just couldn't...their Catholicism was so ingrained they just couldn't get over it. They couldn't see beyond it.

OD: Yeah. So for them that was...it always happened and even if they didn't talk about it it still had...

LP: It still happened and it still flavoured who I was to them, and I was this awful child that had let them down and disgraced them and embarrassed them and, you know?

OD: It's very obvious why that would have those ramifications and why you would want to be separate from that?

LP: Yeah, but you try to, you know, everybody's family is odd or has got difficulties that, you know, they smooth over? And ours was no different to anyone else's in that respect. But for me it was just too big a thing to pretend it hadn't happened, and as much as I didn't want them to sit and talk to me about it every day or every time I met them, their lack of care and their lack of

concern or interest just reinforced to me how unloving they were, really. I said to them: 'You can either be different or you can stay the same. If you stay the same, I don't want you in my life'. And they stayed the same.

OD: Did they respond to the letter, or?

LP: No. No. My family – half of my family – felt I'd done the right the thing, half of them felt I hadn't.

OD: So, you see some of your family?

LP: I was in contact with some of them for another few years and then...My sister and my middle brother – the two favourites – they obviously felt what I had done was wrong and it, you know, they were worried about the anguish it had caused them. My sister said: 'I haven't slept since I got that letter' – because I wrote to all of them. And I wrote to all of them saying to each of them what I wanted to say to each of them. And the other two, my eldest brother and his wife, and my youngest brother and his wife, were very supportive and they said: 'We know exactly what you're saying here. You're very brave to take them on' and blah-de-blah. I visited them for quite some time and then when my parents died...My mother died – it must be coming up for seven or eight years now. I didn't know she was ill. I knew she'd gone into care because – no. My father died first. My father was a very brutal man when he was younger, very uncaring, very emotionally abusive. A bully, really. But as he got older, he got better because he mellowed a bit, whereas my mother, I think, got worse. He died first and I was quite saddened when I heard he had died. I was just...We were just coming back from *location redacted*, seeing our son at uni and I got a phone call from my sister-in-law – not from any of my family, but from my sister-in-law – to say that my dad was in hospital. He was ninety-one. His heart

was bad and he, he was very poorly. And I cried the whole way home, I was really upset. And I said, you know, at the end of the day he's still my dad. And then I think somebody rang me the next day to say that he'd died. There was never any discussion about me coming for the funeral, or we'd love you to put this all to bed. Nothing. Nobody rang me.

OD: So, it was just too hard for them do you think? There was no...they couldn't conceive of how it could all come back together? That must have been really hard for you?

LP: So...So I said to *name of husband redacted*: "What do I want to do?" And you know the way that funerals in Northern Ireland are so quick? You die and you're in a box the next day and then you're packed off. *Name of husband redacted* said to me: "Whatever you want to do I will support you. If you want to go and see them all again, I will go with you. If you want to go and just go in at the end of the funeral..." He said: "If you want to go and go to the grave afterwards, I will go. Whatever." And I said: "Well, you know what, I'm not going to go to a funeral and be overwhelmed by the emotion of the funeral and have this sort of deathbed reconciliation with everyone." Knowing that it's just not meant and it's just not ...I'm not going to go so that they can see that I've gone, you know? In the same way that they'll be standing at church with all the people that knew daddy and everyone will say: "Oh he was a great chap, a great chap." The hypocrisy of it really got to me, and I thought I will go and pay respects to my father – but I will not do it on their timescale. So that's what I did. I didn't go to the funeral. And I went over to Ireland after he'd been buried, went to his grave and said goodbye.

OD: I think that's a very brave decision, actually.

LP: And then when my mother died...I knew that my mother had gone into care because when my father died – although she was ten years younger than him – she wasn't coping very well and my eldest brother was her carer, and he, she was driving him nuts. And then my sister-in-law rang up and said: "Your mother's going in a home because *brother's name redacted* is going to have a breakdown if she doesn't go in a home." And I had always said to my mother: "I will never let you go into a home." But...So then she died within nine months. I mean there was a whole lot more of them that could've looked after her if they'd wanted to. My brother – my middle brother and my sister – are both very financially well off. I mean megabucks well off. They could have had her to live with them or...But they wouldn't have done that because they're just not those type of people. So, then she died and my youngest brother and rang me up and said: "Mother's died." And I went: "Oh, I'm sad to hear that, *brother's name redacted*." And that was it. And then again, her funeral, and the same thing...and we did the same thing. We went over afterward and read the gravestone that said how warm and loving...

[Recording cuts off and a new one started at this point]

LP: ...and I have lived with that consequence for thirty-five years. Even now I've just, I have written to...because I know they changed the law, but in Northern Ireland the adoption laws are slightly different as well. But I have written to whoever the department is to say: 'These are my details. If *son's name redacted* ever tries to find me'...Because obviously my details on file will be for my parent's home, and I'm not there anymore.

OD: So, you've updated them?

LP: So, I've updated them. But there's always this feeling that you don't deserve to be in his life... That you don't deserve to be known to him, or... that you don't deserve a lot of stuff in life. And I mean that's really what I've battled with for thirty-odd years, is that it has had a flavour through all of my life. I mean I've gone on, I've had a very successful career, I've been married to *husband's name redacted* for thirty-two years nearly. I've got two children. I think I've made a success of my life, but... And I have been incredibly happy, and my children give me great joy now. But it's like a piece of the puzzle that's missing and some people can cope with that – I don't think I've coped with it ever very well. It's always been there every single day. Where is he? What's he doing? Is he married? Have I got grandchildren that I don't know about? But do I have the right? Do I have the right to upset his life by trying to find him? And the answer has always been 'No' – you don't, because you gave him away. You weren't strong enough to stand up to them. You didn't say to them at the time: 'Hold on a minute. Why is this the best thing to do? Who says this is the best thing to do?' But they did, obviously, because they wanted my child.

OD: But can you recognise that now that that agency was taken away from you? So, you know, when you talk about deserving and things like that? That's, that's not your fault?

LP: I mean...

OD: I mean what can you do as a twenty year-old with no income, no support, put in that position?

LP: But the sense of disgrace, the sense of disgrace and that the Catholic Church and the people that believed its ministries... I mean when I talk about the Catholicism, I mean Northern Irish Catholicism, which is divorced from

most other...Catholicism over here isn't practiced like that. It was bigoted, it was evil, it was...it suppressed any good, you know? A-level guilt, you know, is the standing joke isn't it? And if you've had a Catholic education in a Catholic household with my parents, you have no chance really. Because there's no joy, there's no...It's all about appearance and people seeing that you're doing the right thing, you know? The disgrace that they felt about me, you know, that they couldn't mention anything? They couldn't give me any comfort after it because they were so wrapped up in this 'She's such a sinner' mode. I mean I couldn't believe it. My daughter, when she was sixteen, it was Christmas time and she was in a terrible state about something – we didn't know what it was. But anyway, she was telling me that she wasn't well. So, Boxing Day she was crying and all sorts of troubles and I said to her: "I'm going to take you to the on-call doctor, love." "All right, mummy, all right we'll go." So, I took her and she's very upset and she was talking about this pain in her tummy and everything. And the nurse that was dealing with us obviously had access to her records, and she'd been in a few weeks before to get the morning after pill. And she'd got a boyfriend, she'd been with him for a long time, and she hadn't wanted to tell me that she'd slept with him. But she was so distressed because she thought that she was pregnant and we went in and the nurse wouldn't break her confidence and say: "Well, *daughter's name redacted*, I know you were in here two weeks ago." But she was very good and she sort of got to the...and then *daughter's name redacted* started sobbing. And the first thing I did was put my arms around her and said: "Oh, for goodness sake, *daughter's name redacted*, you know, don't worry love. We're here to"...The nurse said: "We'll do a pregnancy test." And I said: "Look, love, please don't worry. Let's find out what we're dealing with and then we'll deal with it." And I put my arms around her and I just thought the poor girl, the poor soul. And anyway, as luck would have it, it was just anxiety. I said: "Please, don't ever go through that again. Just let me know if you're, you know, if something's happened, or..."

OD: But that will have made so much difference to her, to have that understanding?

LP: Yeah.

OD: Because that makes it less scary and makes her more prepared. It makes her, you know...that's such an impressive thing that you've done.

LP: All I could feel was her hurt.

OD: Yeah, because that's...

LP: All my mother could feel was society's shame.

OD: Yeah. And you, you've...

LP: I was a nothing. I was a nothing.

OD: But you've been the victim of that? That has caused you huge pain.

LP: Huge pain.

OD: And you're still dealing with it.

LP: Absolutely. Huge pain.

OD: So, would you like to finish there?

LP: Yeah, yeah, yeah.

OD: If I finish then with just one question – which is a question that I ask everyone, and thank you, as well, because I think you’ve been really honest and it’s clearly been very tough.

LP: Yeah.

OD: What would you like to see come out of something like this? Obviously, there was the inquiry in the South and that had specific results and I was just wondering, if an inquiry does come out of this study what would you want to see happen?

LP: I would like to see some acknowledgement of the fact that the teachings of the Catholic Church with regards to unmarried mothers was harsh and judgemental, and that the reasons that these places existed was because of that. It was because no compassion was taught, no, you know, love, no understanding. It was just ‘these girls are awful and we have to put them somewhere out of reach of society’, you know? The principles of religion to me are love and compassion and feeling – and they exhibited none of that. The people that I hold responsible for where I am in life is the Catholic Church and the fact that, that they...they fostered this, this culture really – and probably still do in Northern Ireland to a certain extent.

OD: So, rather than it being specifically your parents, or specifically the nuns, instead it’s the actual, the Church itself that fosters all these...

LP: The nuns I couldn’t fault. I mean I couldn’t. They showed me love and care – they showed me far more than my parents did.

OD: So, it's above that? It's the actual hierarchy, the ideology behind...?

LP: Yeah. And I meant to say to them that I did write to them and...

OD: Yes, and what was the...

LP: ...I got a letter. I'll show it to you if you want?

OD: I'd love to see it.

LP: Basically, it was a priest who probably is a lot younger than me writing back in his smug Catholic way to say I'll pray for you and 'Oh it must be tough'. It was very banal really, I thought. But nothing more than I would have expected – or less. How...how does he know what it's like?

OD: Yeah.

LP: You know, he's a man, he's a priest, he's been brought up in the noughties. He has no idea what we went through – go through.

OD: So, the letter didn't help you?

LP: It made me quite cross, actually. I laughed at it first and then it made me quite cross.

OD: Yeah. I'm not surprised.

LP: And I just thought you have no idea. You have no idea...what you and your lot have, you know?

OD: Have done?

LP: Yeah. I'll get it...

OD: If you're happy I'll switch off?

LP: I mean it's not even very long.

OD: Okay. We're just going to pause the tape there for a second.

[Interview paused]

OD: Okay we're just re-starting the tape and you've given me the letter.

LP: Yeah, yeah.

OD: Which I've taken a picture of. And I was just wondering how you feel about the fact that they offer you counselling ...

LP: Oh yeah – joke. Absolute joke.

OD: So, is that of concern to you? That...

LP: Absolutely.

OD: ...it would be Catholic...

LP: It's the same thing again.

OD: Yeah. So...

LP: They're going to give, they're going to spit-out the same about 'it was for the best'.

OD: Yeah.

LP: You know?

OD: And do you mention – did you mention, in your letter, the priest who you...

LP: Yes.

OD: ...who gave you those questions [referring the priest in the confessional box]?

LP: Yes.

OD: And then they've said if you can remember...and you can't remember his name?

LP: I don't know his name.

OD: Yeah.

LP: Don't know his name. He was an old man. They're bound to know who was the parish priest there at the time.

OD: Yeah. I mean this is a very short, short letter and it doesn't...I can see why it wouldn't offer...I mean it doesn't offer much? And you haven't had a reply from the Good Shepherds?

LP: No. But I don't hold...I mean I don't hold the nuns...I don't – I mean there is this thing that...you know. I was thinking about what is slavery when people were slaves and, you know, people did awful things to them because at that time they thought it was okay.

OD: Yeah.

LP: And it was a bit like that with *name of Good Shepherd mother and baby home redacted* in the eighties.

OD: Yeah.

LP: They thought it was okay.

OD: Yeah. And I can see that you don't have any specific grievances with nuns in particular.

LP: No.

OD: Your problem is very much with the people who were much higher up – or the very kind of idea of hiding away pregnant women.

LP: I think it was just the...My big thing is with the priests and the nuns that bred this culture of lack of forgiveness and compassion. And it was the Church that...and then the Church sorted the problem, and they took your child from you, you know?

OD: And I suppose that fed into your parents' attitudes as well?

LP: Oh absolutely. Yeah. And they stole, they stole your children basically and you, you know...they did. As I say, one stop shop. That's what was wrong with it.

OD: Taking babies and giving them to Catholic families?

LP: Other Catholic families. There was no...there was no – what's the word I'm looking for? Governance.

OD: Yeah.

LP: There was no governance.

OD: And no independent...I mean there was – from what you've described – there's no impetus for them to want to...

LP: No.

OD: ...find you or help you?

LP: No. No.

OD: Is there anything else you'd...I'm really conscious that this must have been really tough?

LP: No, no. It's not. It's been the least tough thing 'cos I think I've actually got it in my head now, you know? I've got it as much as you can do.

OD: Well, you've been really clear and concise and helpful with chronology and things like that...

LP: But I mean when you get a letter like that it's ridiculous isn't it?

OD: No, I can see why that would give you...

LP: It's just ridiculous. And it just reinforces to you how disinterested they are. How disinterested they were at the time for your welfare, you know? Once they got your child it was 'goodbye, sweetheart'. You know?

OD: Yeah.

LP: Or 'now come on we'll talk to you about it and we'll make you see it our way'.

OD: I think that's what stands out is the counselling through that service?

LP: Yeah.

OD: I can understand why that would not be...

LP: I mean I live in *area in GB redacted*, you know, and if he'd read the letter he would have realised that, you know? [Referring to the fact that LP was being offered counselling by a Northern Ireland service despite the fact she lives in Britain.]

OD: Yeah.

LP: But I don't know how many people...can you give me some idea of how many people have responded to you?

OD: No, I can't actually because we work through different people, so I can only say my experience which is, you know, we've had a good response.

LP: Yeah.

OD: There's no overall sense of it yet, and I certainly wouldn't know how many people would have taken up something like that or anything.

LP: Yeah.

OD: So, I really understand how frustrating something like that must be.

LP: Yeah.

OD: And do you have anything else you want to say?

LP: No.

OD: Are you sure?

LP: When would the study be – or when will the report be available for...

OD: Oh, no problem. Let me just stop the tape. Thank you very much.